3.2.1 Arithmetic of Polynomials

We now have a rich language of polynomials, and we have seen that they can be classified in many ways as well. Now, what can we do with polynomials? Consider a polynomial on x.

We can evaluate the polynomial at a particular value of x. We can ask how the function given by the polynomial changes as x varies. Write the polynomial equation $p(x) = 0$ and solve for x. All this is interesting, and we will be doing plenty of all this as we go along. But there is something else we can do with polynomials, and that is *to treat them like numbers*! We already have a clue to this at the beginning of the chapter when we saw that every positive integer could be represented as a polynomial.

Following arithmetic, we can try to add polynomials, subtract one from another, multiply polynomials, divide one by another. As it turns out, the analogy between numbers and polynomials runs deep, with many interesting properties relating them. For now, it is fun to simply try and define these operations on polynomials and work with them.

Addition of Polynomials

The addition of two polynomials is also a polynomial.

Note

Only like terms can be added. $3x^2 + 5x^2$ gives $8x^2$ but unlike terms such as $3x^2$ and $5x^3$ when added gives $3x^2 + 5x^3$, a new polynomial.

Example 3.4

If $p(x) = 4x^2 - 3x + 2x^3 + 5$ and $q(x) = x^2 + 2x + 4$, then find $p(x) + q(x)$

Solution

Given Polynomial	Standard form
$p(x) = 4x^2 - 3x + 2x^3 + 5$	$2x^3 + 4x^2 - 3x + 5$
$q(x) = x^2 + 2x + 4$	$x^2 + 2x + 4$
$p(x) + q(x) = 2x^3 + 5x^2 - x + 9$	

We see that $p(x) + q(x)$ is also a polynomial. Hence the sum of any two polynomials is also a polynomial.

Subtraction of Polynomials

The subtraction of two polynomials is also a polynomial.

Note

Only like terms can be subtracted. $8x^2 - 5x^2$ gives $3x^2$ but when $5x^3$ is subtracted from $3x^2$ we get, $3x^2 - 5x^3$, a new polynomial.

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